

THE LOST REBEL

The outsider who walked alone, he should have been the best prime minister India never had

■ By S. Prasannarajan

One of the enduring thrills of Indian democracy is the variety of its performers; among them we can't miss every conceivable type, any number of pastiches of the ideal, tragedians and costume artists at their vaudeville best. Chandra Shekhar was an original, and, on July 8, as he took his final curtain call, Indian politics got a lot duller. Whenever he—that bearded gravitas combined with the gruff masculinity of the heartland—was centrestage, we saw the distance between idealism and aspiration shrinking. Consistently defying the moral text of conventional politics, he was an individualist among populists, a pragmatist among dreamers, and a rebel who was tamed by the ruthlessness of power. In a career that paralleled the spasmodic evolution of post-Nehruvian India, he played them all: the romantic who saw salvation in socialism; the Congressman who raged against the party establishment; betrayer of the cause; the first *yatri* of modern politics; opportunist; mentor; friend; loner... Chandra Shekhar lived his life on his own terms, undaunted by public judgements, and in the end, it was a life set apart by formidable talent and fathomless flaws.

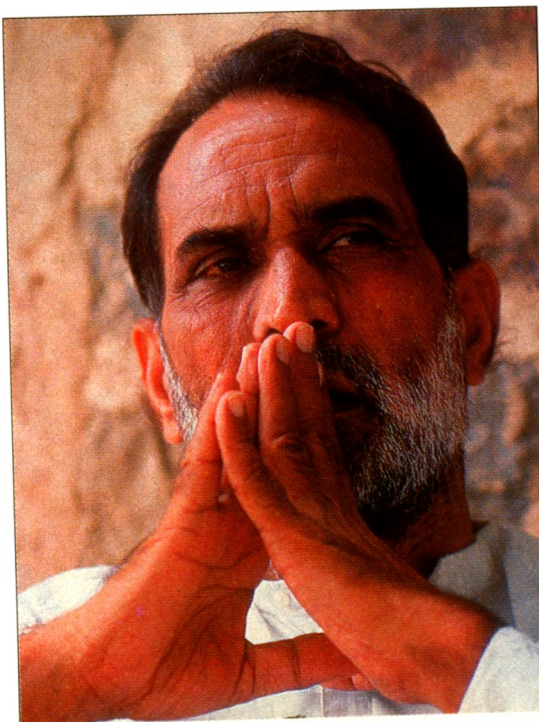
In the beginning, the young man from Ibrahimpatti in Ballia, Uttar Pradesh, was one of those growing number of romantics who thought action was elsewhere, beyond the weary predictability of the Indian National Congress. Swayed by the teachings of Acharya Narendra Dev, Chandra Shekhar began his political career as a socialist. It was the socialist in him that sharpened his rebellious streak, and earned him the title of Young Turk when he became the leader of a conscience-keeping minority in Indira Gandhi's Congress. In her fight against the gray dictatorship

of the Syndicate, the restless progressive was an influential ally. The left-leaning ideological transformation of Indira, resulting in bank nationalisation and other policy shocks of the day, owed a great deal to the fiery idealist. Still, vintage Chandra Shekhar was not a worshipper; as the mythology of Mrs G began to overwhelm the Congress, he refused to give in to the cult of the paramount leader. The rebel who suited her so marvellously until now

politics, it was a moment of revolutionary romance, and for Chandra Shekhar, it was not power that mattered then, but the struggle against power. As president of the Janata Party, there was an aura about him, and he loomed over the first non-Congress government in Delhi as a political savant untainted by exigencies of the office. The middle-aged Turk was on his way to political priesthood, we thought. His *padayatra* from Kanyakumari to Delhi in 1983 was a political masterstroke, a neo-Gandhian experiment with mass politics. Mephistopheles, though, was on the prowl, and even Turks would fall. The year 1989, in retrospect, was Chandra Shekhar's private *annus horribilis*. Prime Minister V.P. Singh, he thought, was an error by history—and a conspiracy by some of his colleagues. It should have been Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar.

When it happened, it looked like a huge anomaly, a massive letdown. There he was, rising from the wreckage of V.P. Singh's flawed, divisive Mandal raj, as the bitter socialist who sold his soul in a Faustian deal. From Race Course Road began Chandra Shekhar's journey to nowhere, to political irrelevance. He should have remained the best Prime Minister India never had. Instead, he became a disposable pawn in the hands of Rajiv Gandhi: jailed by Indira was bad enough; used by the son was pure humiliation.

His short-lived prime ministership, though, had its merits: like the man himself, it was not steeped in bland political correctness. In his autumnal isolation, Chandra Shekhar took refuge in the bucolic make-believe of Bhondsi, his private hermitage. There must have been moments in those lonely evenings when he looked back with a sigh. It was a life caught between the futility of power and the poignancy of struggle. ■



CHANDRA SHEKHAR

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was turning out to be a saboteur. The truth was, like most socialists, he was always one.

As Mrs G's totalitarian temptation culminated in the proclamation of Emergency, Chandra Shekhar was first a victim, then a liberator. Within the Congress, his socialist ideals made him an outsider. He began the second phase in his career as an architect of anti-Congressism, with Jayaprakash Narayan as its spiritual guru. In Indian